

A nasty tangle. I paid a grudging tribute to Miss Marple. She had not been deceived, but had evidently suspected the true state of things with a fair amount of accuracy. I had entirely misread her meaning glance at Griselda.

I had never dreamed of considering Mrs Protheroe in the matter. There has always been rather a suggestion of Caesar's wife about Mrs Protheroe—a quiet, self-contained woman whom one would not suspect of any great depths of feeling.

I had got to this point in my meditations when a tap on my study window roused me. I got up and went to it. Mrs Protheroe was standing outside. I opened the window and she came in, not waiting for an invitation on my part. She crossed the room in a breathless sort of way and dropped down on the sofa.

I had the feeling that I had never really seen her before. The quiet, self-contained woman that I knew had vanished. In her place was a quick-breathing, desperate creature. For the first time I realized that Anne Protheroe was beautiful.

She was a brown-haired woman with a pale face and very deep-set grey eyes. She was flushed now and her breast heaved. It was as though a statue had suddenly come to life. I blinked my eyes at the transformation.

'I thought it best to come,' she said. 'You—you saw just now?'

I bowed my head.

She said very quietly, 'We love each other.'

And even in the middle of her evident distress and agitation she could not keep a little smile from her lips. The smile of a woman who sees something very beautiful and wonderful.

I still said nothing, and she added presently:

'I suppose to you that seems very wrong?'

'Can you expect me to say anything else, Mrs Protheroe?'

'No—no; I suppose not.'

I went on, trying to make my voice as gentle as possible:

'You are a married woman—'

She interrupted me.

'Oh! I know—I know. Do you think I haven't gone over all that again and again? I'm not a bad woman really—I'm not. And things aren't—are't—as you might think they are.'

I said gravely, 'I'm glad of that.'

She asked rather timorously:

'Are you going to tell my husband?'

I said rather dilly:

'There seems to be a general idea that a clergyman is incapable of behaving like a gentleman. That is not true.'

She threw me a grateful glance.

'I'm so unhappy. Oh! I'm so dreadfully unhappy. I can't go on. I simply can't go on. And I don't know what to do.' Her voice rose with a slightly hysterical note in it. 'You don't know what my life is like. I've been miserable with Lucius from the beginning. No woman could be happy with him. I wish he were dead. It's awful, but I do. I'm desperate. I tell you, I'm desperate.'

She started and looked over at the window.

'What was that? I thought I heard someone? Perhaps it's Lawrence.'

I went over to the window, which I had not closed, as I had thought. I stepped out and looked down the garden, but there was no one in sight. Yet I was almost convinced that I, too, had heard someone. Or perhaps it was her certainty that had convinced me.

When I re-entered the room she was leaning forward, drooping her head down. She looked the picture of despair. She said again:

'I don't know what to do. I don't know what to do.'

I came and sat down beside her. I said the things I thought it was my duty to say, and tried to say them with the necessary conviction, uneasily conscious all the time that that same morning I had given voice to the sentiment that a world without Colonel Protheroe in it would be improved for the better.

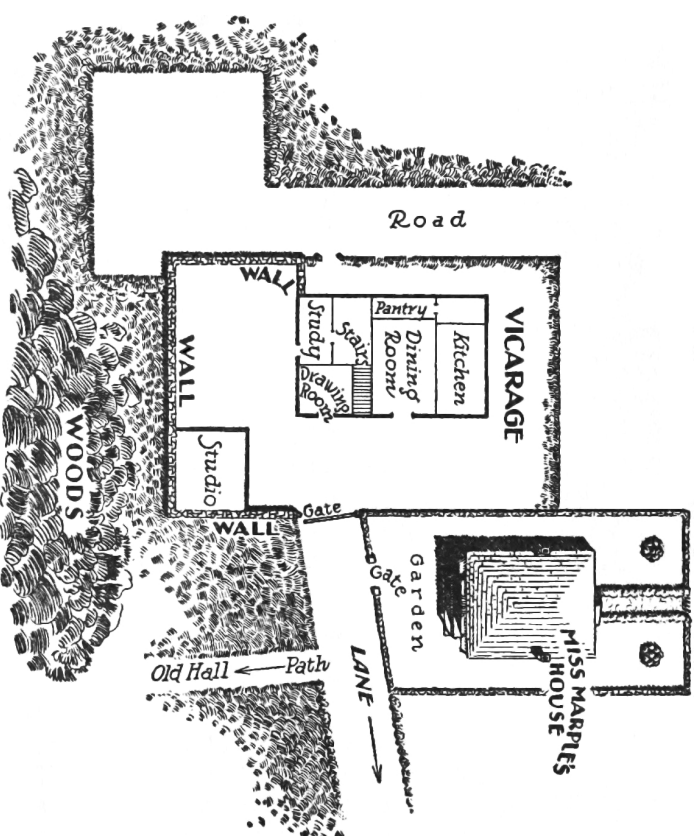
Above all, I begged her to do nothing rash. To leave her home and her husband was a very serious step.

I don't suppose I convinced her. I have lived long enough in the world to know that arguing with anyone in love is next door to useless, but I do think my words brought to her some measure of comfort.

When she rose to go, she thanked me, and promised to think over what I had said.

Nevertheless, when she had gone, I felt very uneasy. I felt that hitherto I had misjudged Anne Protheroe's character. She impressed me now as a very desperate woman, the kind of woman who would stick at nothing, once her

emotions were aroused. And she was desperately, wildly, madly in love with Lawrence Redding, a man several years younger than herself. I didn't like it.



I had no idea there was anyone in the studio. There had been no voices from within to warn me, and I suppose that my own footsteps made no noise upon the grass.

I opened the door and then stopped awkwardly on the threshold. For there were two people in the studio, and the man's arms were round the woman and he was kissing her passionately.

The two people were the artist, Lawrence Redding, and Mrs Protheroe.

I backed out precipitately and beat a retreat to my study. There I sat down in a chair, took out my pipe, and thought things over. The discovery had come as a great shock to me. Especially since my conversation with Lettice that afternoon, I had felt fairly certain that there was some kind of understanding growing up between her and the young man. Moreover, I was convinced that she herself thought so. I felt positive that she had no idea of the artist's feelings for her stepmother.

That seemed final, so I went. But as I did so, I wondered. We are not used to mysteries in St Mary Mead.

So much is this the case that as I emerged from the gate I was pounced upon. Miss Hartnell is very good at pouncing in a heavy and cumbersome way.

'I saw you!' she exclaimed with ponderous humour. 'And I *was* so excited. Now you can tell us all about it.'

'About what?'

'The mysterious lady! Is she a widow or has she a husband somewhere?'

'I really couldn't say. She didn't tell me.'

'How very peculiar. One would think she would be certain to mention something casually. It almost looks, doesn't it, as though she had a reason for not speaking?'

'I really don't see that.'

'Ah! but as dear Miss Marple says, you are so unworldly, dear Vicar. Tell me, has she known Dr Haydock long?'

'She didn't mention him, so I don't know.'

'Really? But what did you talk about then?'

'Pictures, music, books,' I said truthfully.

Miss Hartnell, whose only topics of conversation are the purely personal, looked suspicious and unbelieving. Taking advantage of a momentary hesitation on her part as to how to proceed next, I bade her good night and walked rapidly away.

I called in at a house farther down the village and returned to the Vicarage by the garden gate, passing, as I did so, the danger point of Miss Marple's garden. However, I did not see how it was humanly possible for the news of my visit to Mrs Lestrangle to have yet reached her ears, so I felt reasonably safe.

As I latched the gate, it occurred to me that I would just step down to the shed in the garden which young Lawrence Redding was using as a studio, and see for myself how Griselda's portrait was progressing.

I append a rough sketch here which will be useful in the light of after happenings, only sketching in such details as are necessary.

Chapter 4

I had entirely forgotten that we had asked Lawrence Redding to dinner that night. When Griselda burst in and scolded me, pointing out that it lacked two minutes to dinner time, I was quite taken aback.

'I hope everything will be all right,' Griselda called up the stairs after me. 'I've thought over what you said at lunch, and I've really thought of some quite good things to eat.'

I may say, in passing, that our evening meal amply bore out Griselda's assertion that things went much worse when she tried than when she didn't. The menu was ambitious in conception, and Mary seemed to have taken a perverse pleasure in seeing how best she could alternate undercooking and overcooking. Some oysters which Griselda had ordered, and which would seem to be beyond the reach of incompetence, were unfortunately not able to sample, as we had nothing in the house to open them with—an omission which was discovered only when the moment for eating them arrived.

I had rather doubted whether Lawrence Redding would put in an appearance. He might very easily have sent an excuse. However, he arrived punctually enough, and the four of us went in to dinner.

Lawrence Redding has an undeniably attractive personality. He is, I suppose, about thirty years of age. He has dark hair, but his eyes are of a brilliant, almost startling blue. He is the kind of young man who does everything well. He is good at games, an excellent shot, a good amateur, and can tell a first-rate story. He is capable of making any party go. He has, I think, Irish blood in his veins. He is not, at all, one's idea of the typical artist. Yet I believe he is a clever painter in the modern style. I know very little of painting myself.

It was only natural that on this particular evening he should appear a shade *distrain*. On the whole, he carried off things very well. I don't think Griselda or Dennis noticed anything wrong. Probably I should not have noticed anything myself if I had not known beforehand.

Griselda and Dennis were particularly gay—full of jokes about Dr Stone and Miss Cram—the Local Scandal! It suddenly came home to me with something of a pang that Dennis is nearer Griselda's age than I am. He calls me Uncle Len but her Griselda. It gave me, somehow, a lonely feeling.

I must, I think, have been upset by Mrs Protheroe. I'm not usually given to such unprofitable reflections.

Griselda and Dennis went rather far now and then, but I hadn't the heart to check them. I have always thought it a pity that the mere presence of a clergyman should have a damping effect.

Lawrence took a gay part in the conversation. Nevertheless I was aware of his eyes continually straying to where I sat, and I was not surprised when after dinner he manoeuvred to get me into the study.

As soon as we were alone, his manner changed. His face became grave and anxious. He looked almost haggard.

'You've surprised our secret, sir,' he said. 'What are you going to do about it?'

I could speak far more plainly to Redding than I could to Mrs Protheroe, and I did so. He took it very well.

'Of course,' he said when I had finished. 'You're bound to say all this. You're a parson. I don't mean that in any way offensively. As a matter of fact, I think you're probably right. But this isn't the usual sort of thing between Anne and me.'

I told him that people had been saying that particular phrase since the dawn of time, and a queer little smile creased his lips.

'You mean everyone thinks their case is unique? Perhaps so. But one thing you must believe.'

He assured me that so far—'there was nothing wrong in it.' Anne, he said, was one of the truest and most loyal women that ever lived. What was going to happen he didn't know.

'If this were only a book,' he said gloomily, 'the old man would die—and a good riddance to everybody.'

I reproved him.

'Oh! I didn't mean I was going to stick him in the back with a knife, though I'd offer my best thanks to anyone else who did so. There's not a soul in the world who's got a good word to say for him. I rather wonder the first

Yet I wondered more and more what had brought such a woman as Mrs Lestrangle to St Mary Mead. She was so very clearly a woman of the world that it seemed a strange taste to bury herself in a country village.

In the clear light of her drawing room I had an opportunity of observing her closely for the first time.

She was a very tall woman. Her hair was gold with a tinge of red in it. Her eyebrows and eyelashes were dark, whether by art or by nature I could not decide. If she was, as I thought, made up, it was done very artistically. There was something Sphinxlike about her face when it was in repose, and she had the most curious eyes I have ever seen—they were almost golden in shade.

Her clothes were perfect, and she had all the ease of manner of a well-bred woman, and yet there was something about her that was incongruous and baffling. You felt that she was a mystery. The word Griselda had used occurred to me—*sinister*. Absurd, of course, and yet—was it so absurd? The thought sprang unbidden into my mind.

'This woman would stick at nothing.'

Our talk was on most normal lines—pictures, books, old churches. Yet somehow I got very strongly the impression that there was something else—something of quite a different nature that Mrs Lestrangle wanted to say to me.

I caught her eyes on me once or twice, looking at me with a curious hesitancy, as though she were unable to make up her mind. She kept the talk, I noticed, strictly to impersonal subjects. She made no mention of a husband, or of friends or relations.

But all the time there was that strange, urgent appeal in her glance. It seemed to say, 'Shall I tell you? I want to. Can't you help me?'

Yet in the end it died away—or perhaps it had all been my fancy. I had the feeling that I was being dismissed. I rose and took my leave. As I went out of the room, I glanced back and saw her staring after me with a puzzled, doubtful expression. On an impulse I came back.

'If there is anything I can do—'

She said doubtfully, 'It's very kind of you—'

We were both silent. Then she said:

'I wish I knew. It's difficult. No, I don't think anyone can help me. But thank you for offering to do so.'

'Miss Marple may be mistaken.'

'She never is. That kind of old cat is always right.' She paused a minute and then said, with a quick, sidelong glance at me, 'You do believe me, don't you? I mean, that there's nothing between Lawrence and me.'

'My dear Griselda,' I said surprised. 'Of course.'

My wife came across and kissed me.

'I wish you weren't so terribly easy to deceive, Len. You'd believe me whatever I said.'

'I should hope so. But, my dear, I do beg of you to guard your tongue and be careful what you say. These women are singularly deficient in humour, remember, and take everything seriously.'

'What they need,' said Griselda, 'is a little immorality in their lives. Then they wouldn't be so busy looking for it in other people's.'

On this she left the room, and, glancing at my watch, I hurried out to pay some visits that ought to have been made earlier in the day.

The Wednesday evening service was sparsely attended as usual, but when I came out through the Church, after disrobing in the Vestry, it was empty save for a woman who stood staring up at one of our windows. We have some rather fine old stained glass, and indeed the Church itself is well worth looking at. She turned at my footsteps, and I saw that it was Mrs Lestrangle.

We both hesitated a moment and then I said:

'I hope you like our little church.'

'I've been admiring the screen,' she said.

Her voice was pleasant, low yet very distinct with a clearcut enunciation. She added:

'I'm so sorry to have missed your wife yesterday.'

We talked a few minutes longer about the church. She was evidently a cultured woman who knew something of church history and architecture. We left the building together and walked down the road, since one way to the Vicarage led past her house. As we arrived at the gate, she said pleasantly:

'Come in, won't you? And tell me what you think of what I have done.'

I accepted the invitation. Little Gates had formerly belonged to an Anglo-Indian Colonel, and I could not help feeling relieved by the disappearance of the brass tables and the Burmese idols. It was furnished now very simply but in exquisite taste. There was a sense of harmony and rest about it.

Mrs Protheroe didn't do him in. I met her once, years ago, and she looked quite capable of it. One of those calm, dangerous women. He goes blustering along, stirring up trouble everywhere, mean as the devil, and with a particularly nasty temper. You don't know what Anne has had to stand from him. If I had a penny in the world I'd take her away without any more ado.'

Then I spoke to him very earnestly. I begged him to leave St Mary Mead. By remaining there, he could only bring greater unhappiness on Anne Protheroe than was already her lot. People would talk; the matter would get to Colonel Protheroe's ears—and things would be made infinitely worse for her.

Lawrence protested.

'Nobody knows a thing about it except you, padre.'

'My dear young man, you underestimate the detective instinct of village life. In St Mary Mead everyone knows your most intimate affairs. There is no detective in England equal to a spinster lady of uncertain age with plenty of time on her hands.'

He said easily that that was all right. Everyone thought it was Lettice.

'Has it occurred to you,' I asked, 'that possibly Lettice might think so herself?'

He seemed quite surprised by the idea. Lettice, he said, didn't care a hang about him. He was sure of that.

'She's a queer sort of girl,' he said. 'Always seems in a kind of dream, and yet underneath I believe she's really rather practical. I believe all that vague stuff is a pose. Lettice knows jolly well what she's doing. And there's a funny vindictive streak in her. The queer thing is that she hates Anne. Simply loathes her. And yet Anne's been a perfect angel to her always.'

I did not, of course, take his word for this last. To infatuated young men, their innamorata always behaves like an angel. Still, to the best of my observation, Anne had always behaved to her stepdaughter with kindness and fairness. I had been surprised myself that afternoon at the bitterness of Lettice's tone.

We had to leave the conversation there, because Griselda and Dennis burst in upon us and said I was not to make Lawrence behave like an old fogey.

'Oh! dear,' said Griselda, throwing herself into an arm chair. 'How I would like a thrill of some kind. A murder—or even a burglary.'

'I don't suppose there's anyone much worth burgling,' said Lawrence, trying to enter into her mood. 'Unless we stole Miss Hartnell's false teeth.'

'They do click horribly,' said Griselda. 'But you're wrong about there being no one worth while. There's some marvellous old silver at Old Hall. Trencher salts and a Charles II tazza—all kinds of things like that. Worth thousands of pounds, I believe.'

'The old man would probably shoot you with an army revolver,' said Dennis. 'Just the sort of thing he'd enjoy doing.'

'Oh! we'd get in first and hold him up,' said Griselda. 'Who's got a revolver?' 'I've got a Mauser pistol,' said Lawrence.

'Have you? How exciting! Why do you have it?'

'Souvenir of the War,' said Lawrence briefly.

'Old Protheroe was showing the silver to Stone today,' volunteered Dennis. 'Old Stone was pretending to be no end interested in it.'

'I thought they'd quarrelled about the barrow,' said Griselda.

'Oh! they've made that up,' said Dennis. 'I can't think what people want to grub about in barrows for, anyway.'

'Tharman Stone puzzles me,' said Lawrence. 'I think he must be very absent-minded. You'd swear sometimes he knew nothing about his own subject.'

'That's love,' said Dennis. 'Sweet Gladys Cram, you are no sham. Your teeth are white and fill me with delight. Come, fly with me, my bride to be. And at the Blue Boar, on the bedroom floor—'

'That's enough, Dennis,' I said.

'Well,' said Lawrence Redding, 'I must be off. Thank you very much, Mrs Clement, for a very pleasant evening.'

Griselda and Dennis saw him off. Dennis returned to the study alone. Something had happened to ruffle the boy. He wandered about the room aimlessly, frowning and kicking the furniture.

Our furniture is so shabby already that it can hardly be damaged further, but I felt impelled to utter a mild protest.

'Sorry,' said Dennis.

He was silent for a moment and then burst out:

'What an absolutely rotten thing gossip is!'

I was a little surprised. Dennis does not usually take that attitude.

'What's the matter?' I asked.

'I don't know whether I ought to tell you.'

I was more and more surprised.

Chapter 3

'MASTY old cat,' said Griselda as soon as the door was closed. She made a face in the direction of the departing visitors and then looked at me and laughed.

'Len, do you really suspect me of having an affair with Lawrence Redding?'

'My dear, of course not.'

'But you thought Miss Marple was hinting at it. And you rose to my defence simply beautifully. Like—like an angry tiger.'

A momentary uneasiness assailed me. A clergyman of the Church of England ought never to put himself in the position of being described as an angry tiger. However, I trusted that Griselda exaggerated.

'I felt the occasion could not pass without a protest,' I said. 'But Griselda, I wish you would be a little more careful in what you say.'

'Do you mean the cannibal story?' she asked. 'Or the suggestion that Lawrence was painting me in the nude? If they only knew that he was painting me in a thick cloak with a very high fur collar—the sort of thing that you could go quite purely to see the Pope in—not a bit of sinful flesh showing anywhere! In fact, it's all marvellously pure. Lawrence never even attempts to make love to me—I can't think why.'

'Surely, knowing that you're a married woman—'

'Don't pretend to come out of the Ark, Len. You know very well that an attractive woman with an elderly husband is a kind of gift from heaven to a young man. There must be some other reason—It's not that I'm unattractive—I'm not.'

'Surely you don't want him to make love to you?'

'N-n-o,' said Griselda with more hesitation than I thought becoming.

'If he's in love with Lettice Protheroe—'

'Miss Marple didn't seem to think he was.'

about his daughter carrying on with young Bailey. And all the time it was that mix of a wife of his.'

She was looking full at Griselda as she spoke, and I suddenly felt a wild surge of anger.

'Don't you think, Miss Marple?' I said, 'that we're all inclined to let our tongues run away with us too much? Charity thinketh no evil, you know. Inestimable harm may be done by the foolish wagging of tongues in ill-natured gossip.'

'Dear Vicar,' said Miss Marple, 'you are so unworldly. I'm afraid that, observing human nature for as long as I have done, one gets not to expect very much from it. I daresay idle tittle-tattle is very wrong and unkind, but it is so often true, isn't it?'

That last Parthian shot went home.

'It's such an absolutely rotten thing,' Dennis said again. 'Going round and saying things. Not even saying them. Hinting them. No, I'm damned—sorry—if I'll tell you! It's absolutely rotten.'

I looked at him curiously but I did not press him further. I wondered very much, though. It is very unlike Dennis to take anything to heart.

Griselda came in at that moment.

'Miss Wetherby's just rung up,' she said. 'Mrs Lestrangle went out at a quarter past eight and hasn't come in yet. Nobody knows where she's gone.'

'Why should they know?'

'But it isn't to Dr Haydock's. Miss Wetherby does know that, because she telephoned to Miss Hartnell who lives next door to him and who would have been sure to see her.'

'It is a mystery to me,' I said, 'how anyone ever gets any nourishment in this place. They must eat their meals standing up by the window so as to be sure of not missing anything.'

'And that's not all,' said Griselda bubbling with pleasure. 'They've found out about the Blue Boar. Dr Stone and Miss Cram have got rooms next door to each other *but*—' she waved an impressive forefinger—'*no communicating door!*'

'That,' I said, 'must be very disappointing to everybody.'

At which Griselda laughed.

Thursday started badly. Two of the ladies of my parish elected to quarrel about the church decorations. I was called in to adjudicate between two middle-aged ladies, each of whom was literally trembling with rage. If it had not been so painful, it would have been quite an interesting physical phenomenon.

Then I had to reprove two of our choir boys for persistent sweet sucking during the hours of divine service, and I had an uneasy feeling that I was not doing the job as whole-heartedly as I should have done.

Then our organist, who is distinctly 'touchy,' had taken offence and had to be smoothed down.

And four of my poorer parishioners declared open rebellion against Miss Hartnell who came to me bursting with rage about it.

I was just going home when I met Colonel Protheroe. He was in high good humour, having sentenced three poachers in his capacity as magistrate.

'Firmness,' he shouted in his stentorian voice. He is slightly deaf and raises his voice accordingly as deaf people often do. 'That's what's needed nowadays—firmness! Make an example. That rogue Archer came out yesterday and is vowing vengeance against me, I hear. Impudent scoundrel. Threatened men live long, as the saying goes. I'll show him what his vengeance is worth, next time I catch him taking my pheasants. Lax! We're too lax nowadays! I believe in showing a man up for what he is. You're always being asked to consider a man's wife and children. Damned nonsense. Fiddlesticks. Why should a man escape the consequences of his acts just because he whines about his wife and children? It's all the same to me—no matter what a man is—doctor, lawyer, clergyman, poacher, drunken wastrel—if you catch him on the wrong side of the law, let the law punish him. You agree with me, I'm sure.'

'You forget,' I said. 'My calling obliges me to respect one quality above all others—the quality of mercy.'

'Well, I'm a just man. No one can deny that.'

I did not speak and he said sharply:

'Why don't you answer? A penny for your thoughts, man.'

I hesitated, then I decided to speak.

'I was thinking,' I said, 'that, when my times comes, I should be sorry if the only plea I had to offer was that of justice. Because it might mean that only justice would be meted out to me.'

'Pah! What we need is a little militant Christianity. I've always done my duty, I hope. Well, no more of that. I'll be along this evening as I said. We'll make it a quarter past six instead of six, if you don't mind. I've got to see a man in the village.'

'That will suit me quite well.'

He flourished his stick and strode away. Turning, I ran into Hawes. I thought he looked distinctly ill this morning. I had meant to upbraid him mildly for various matters, in his province, which had been muddled or shelved, but seeing his white, strained face, I felt that the man was ill.

I said as much and he denied it, but not very vehemently. Finally he confessed that he was not feeling too fit, and appeared ready to accept my advice of going home to bed.

'Oh!' cried Miss Wetherby excitedly. 'I quite forgot. I knew I had some news for you. I saw Dr Haydock coming out of Mrs Lestrangé's cottage.'

Everyone looked at each other.

'Perhaps she's ill,' suggested Mrs Price Ridley.

'It must have been very sudden, if so,' said Miss Harnell. 'For I saw her walking round her garden at three o'clock this afternoon, and she seemed in perfect health.'

'She and Dr Haydock must be old acquaintances,' said Mrs Price Ridley, 'He's been very quiet about it.'

'It's curious,' said Miss Wetherby, 'that he's never mentioned it.'

'As a matter of fact—' said Griselda in a low, mysterious voice, and stopped. Everyone leaned forward excitedly.

'I happen to *know*,' said Griselda impressively. 'Her husband was a missionary. Terrible story. *He was eaten*, you know. Actually eaten. And she was forced to become the Chief's head wife. Dr Haydock was with an expedition and rescued her.'

For a moment excitement was rife, then Miss Marple said reproachfully, but with a smile:

'Naughty girl!'

She tapped Griselda reprovingly on the arm.

'Very unwise thing to do, my dear. If you make up these things, people are quite likely to believe them. And sometimes that leads to complications.'

A distinct frost had come over the assembly. Two of the ladies rose to take their departure.

'I wonder if there is anything between young Lawrence Redding and Lettice Protheroe,' said Miss Wetherby. 'It certainly looks like it. What do you think, Miss Marple?'

Miss Marple seemed thoughtful.

'I shouldn't have said so myself. Not *Lettice*. Quite another person, I should have said.'

'But Colonel Protheroe must have thought—'

'He has always struck me as rather a stupid man,' said Miss Marple. 'The kind of man who gets the wrong idea into his head and is obstinate about it. Do you remember Joe Bucknell who used to keep the Blue Boar? Such a to-do